



Standing Committee on National Food Security and Research meets

The 26th meeting of the Standing Committee on National Food Security and Research was held on Thursday, April 30, 2026, at 2:00 p.m. in the Committee Room of the National Agricultural Research Centre (NARC), Chak Shehzad, Islamabad, under the chairmanship of Syed Tariq Hussain, MNA. The meeting commenced with the recitation from the Holy Quran, followed by confirmation of the minutes of the previous meeting.

On a Point of Order regarding the potato crop crisis, the Committee expressed grave concern that, despite its timely intervention, the Ministry failed to implement necessary measures to protect farmers, who were compelled to sell their produce below production cost, resulting in significant financial losses. The Committee cautioned that such persistent losses are likely to discourage potato cultivation in the near future, thereby posing risks to agricultural sustainability and food security. It further noted that the Ministry had been directed three months earlier to take immediate and concrete actions, including exploring new trade opportunities, identifying alternative export routes, facilitating multiple-entry visas for exporters, and improving transportation and logistics; however, no meaningful progress has been observed to date. In view of this inaction, the Committee directed the Ministry to convene an urgent meeting on Monday at the Foreign Office with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and all relevant stakeholders, including the Ministries of Commerce, FBR, and Customs, to develop a coordinated strategy for enhancing agricultural exports, particularly for potatoes and the upcoming crops such as mangoes, maize, and rice, and to adopt a proactive approach to prevent recurrence of similar losses.

The Committee also expressed concern over frequent transfers of the Secretary, Ministry of National Food Security and Research, stressing the importance of continuity in leadership and directing that steps be taken to ensure officials complete their tenure.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs informed the Committee of its readiness to facilitate engagements between Pakistan and importing countries, while emphasizing that sustained follow-up and integrated inter-ministerial coordination are essential for tangible outcomes.

The Committee directed the Ministry to provide an update in the next meeting regarding existing mango export MOUs, potential new agreements, ongoing negotiations, alternate trade routes, visa facilitation, and transportation arrangements. It was also directed that representatives from NLC and the Ministry of Communications attend the next meeting.

The Ministry of Commerce informed the Committee that, through an official notification, the ban on mango exports has been extended until May 30, 2026, as compared to the earlier date of May 10. The Committee expressed dissatisfaction with this decision, noting its adverse impact on early mango varieties such as Dussehri and Sonaro, which are ready for harvest and export during this period, potentially causing financial losses to growers and exporters. The Committee directed that the Commerce Secretary attend the next meeting in person to enable on-the-spot decision-making.

Vice President of the Multan Mango Growers Association, apprised the Committee that Pakistan's annual mango production ranges between 1.6 to 2 million tons; however, only around 5 percent is exported due to limited value addition, while the remaining 95 percent is consumed domestically. He noted that while previously standardized mango-based products such as nectar and juice contained 30–50 percent and 15 percent fruit content, respectively, the market has recently seen an increase in synthetic mango-flavored beverages. He expressed concern that such products may contain harmful ingredients, allegedly posing serious health risks, including links to cancer and adverse effects on children under 16, and called for their immediate withdrawal from the market. He further stated that casualties were reportedly observed in Islamabad in the previous week allegedly linked to consumption of such beverages. Taking serious note, the Committee directed the Ministry to obtain comprehensive reports from the World Health Organization, Ministry of Health, and other relevant institutions, and to submit a consolidated report within five days. It further directed that the Ministry of Science and Technology and the Pakistan Standards and Quality Control Authority be invited to the next meeting for technical input and regulatory review.

On agenda item regarding rice sector exports, the Committee was informed that despite regional challenges, the sector recorded export growth during the previous year. However, concern was expressed over increasing competition in international markets following the lifting of restrictions on Indian rice exports, resulting in more competitive pricing from India. The Committee emphasized the need for a strategic and proactive approach to enhance Pakistan's export competitiveness. The Rice Exporters Association was directed to submit, in writing, detailed proposals to improve export performance, including measures to enhance competitiveness, reduce production and logistical costs, improve quality standards, and strengthen branding and market access, particularly in comparison with regional competitors such as India.

The meeting was attended by the Honorable Members Waseem Qadir, Rana Muhammad Hayat Khan, Nadeem Abbas, Ms. Musarrat Asif Khawaja (via Zoom), Abdul Qadir Khan, Nazir Ahmed Bhugio, Syed Javed Ali Shah Jillani, Syed Abrar Ali Shah, Zulfiqar Ali Behan, Syed Ayaz Ali Shah Sheerazi, and Usman Ali, along with senior officials from the Ministry of National Food Security and Research, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and the Ministry of Commerce, as well as representatives of the Rice Exporters Association.